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Tabernacle altar

4.2.2 Tabernacle altar

References:

Hebrew מִזְבֵּחַ (mizbeach) EXO 27:1, EXO 27:1, EXO 27:5, EXO 27:5, EXO 27:6, EXO 27:7, EXO 28:43, EXO 29:12, EXO 29:12, EXO 29:13, EXO 29:16, EXO 29:18, EXO 29:20, EXO 29:21, EXO 29:25, EXO 29:36, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:37, EXO 29:38, EXO 29:44, EXO 30:18, EXO 30:20, EXO 30:28, EXO 31:9, EXO 35:16, EXO 38:1, EXO 38:3, EXO 38:4, EXO 38:7, EXO 38:30, EXO 38:30, EXO 39:39, EXO 40:6, EXO 40:7, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:10, EXO 40:29, EXO 40:30, EXO 40:32, EXO 40:33, LEV 1:5, LEV 1:7, LEV 1:8, LEV 1:9, LEV 1:11, LEV 1:11, LEV 1:12, LEV 1:13, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:15, LEV 1:16, LEV 1:17, LEV 2:2, LEV 2:8, LEV 2:9, LEV 2:12, LEV 3:2, LEV 3:5, LEV 3:8, LEV 3:11, LEV 3:13, LEV 3:16, LEV 4:7, LEV 4:10, LEV 4:18, LEV 4:18, LEV 4:19, LEV 4:25, LEV 4:25, LEV 4:26, LEV 4:30, LEV 4:30, LEV 4:31, LEV 4:34, LEV 4:34, LEV 4:35, LEV 5:9, LEV 5:9, LEV 5:12, LEV 6:2, LEV 6:2, LEV 6:3, LEV 6:3, LEV 6:5, LEV 6:6, LEV 6:7, LEV 6:8, LEV 7:2, LEV 7:5, LEV 7:31, LEV 8:11, LEV 8:11, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:15, LEV 8:16, LEV 8:19, LEV 8:21, LEV 8:24, LEV 8:28, LEV 8:30, LEV 9:7, LEV 9:8, LEV 9:9, LEV 9:9, LEV 9:10, LEV 9:12, LEV 9:13, LEV 9:14, LEV 9:17, LEV 9:18, LEV 9:20, LEV 9:24, LEV 10:12, LEV 14:20, LEV 16:12, LEV 16:18, LEV 16:18, LEV 16:20, LEV 16:25, LEV 16:33, LEV 17:6, LEV 17:11, LEV 21:23, LEV 22:22, NUM 3:26, NUM 3:31, NUM 4:13, NUM 4:14, NUM 4:26, NUM 5:25, NUM 5:26, NUM 7:1, NUM 7:10, NUM 7:10, NUM 7:11, NUM 7:84, NUM 7:88, NUM 17:3, NUM 17:4, NUM 17:11, NUM 18:3, NUM 18:5, NUM 18:7, NUM 18:17, DEU 12:27, DEU 12:27, DEU 16:21, DEU 26:4, JOS 22:29, 1SA 2:28, 1SA 2:33, 1KI 1:50, 1KI 1:51, 1KI 1:53, 1KI 2:28, 1KI 2:29, 1CH 21:29, 2CH 1:5, 2CH 1:6

References:

Rim, ledge:

Hebrew כַּרְכֹּב (karkov) EXO 27:5, EXO 38:4

Description:

The altar of the movable tabernacle (Timnah Park model) (© Ori229, CC BY-SA 3.0, via Wikimedia Commons)The Tabernacle altar was made of acacia wood overlaid, perhaps inside and out, with bronze. It measured five cubits (2.5 meters; 8.3 feet) on a side and stood three cubits (1.5 meters; 5 feet) high. Around its top was a kind of ledge or rim (*karkov* in Hebrew), the purpose of which is not given. The altar was hollow.

Translation:

See 4.2 Altars<REALIA:4.2> and 4.2.1 Stone altar<REALIA:4.2.1> above.

Rim, ledge: The Hebrew word *karkov* is found only in EXO 27:5 and EXO 38:4, and its meaning is unclear. Some scholars think of it as a decorative "rim" (GNT) around the altar that could also support the weight of the altar when lifted by the rings on the grating (EXO 27:4; see 4.2.3 Temple altar<REALIA:4.2.3> for an illustration of a rim). Others imagine that it may have been a "ledge" (RSV) wide enough for the officiating priests to stand on, but this is unlikely since the altar itself was only about 1.5 meters (5 feet) high.

It is not clear whether this rim was at the top, the middle, or the bottom of the altar. Neither is it clear whether it was on the inside or the outside of the altar. NAB translates *karkov* simply as "around," since its root meaning may have been to surround or encircle. EXO 27:5 a in NAB reads "Put it [the grating] down around the altar, on the ground."

Note that the Hebrew clause in EXO 27:5 uses both the words "under" and "below," possibly for emphasis or clarity. NJPSV has "Set the mesh below, under the ledge of the altar," and NJB says "You will put it below the ledge of the altar, underneath." Since there is so much uncertainty about the meaning of these terms, translators must choose either the idea of a "ledge" or a "rim." We may assume that it was a structural rim located probably around the top of the altar.